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1931, ‘Why I Am an Atheist’

While we can never know for certain what Bhagat Singh really thought about dying in the face of the inevitable death that awaited him, there is, nevertheless, this twentieth century moment in India to which we have already referred, where acts of self-sacrifice are deemed necessary as the revolutionaries strive to create a new world. Jail time was considered vital by Bhagat Singh because of the opportunities it afforded in reading and self-analysis. Awaiting sentence upon conclusion of the special tribunal proceedings, he put this in his letter to Sukhdev, explaining,

> I want to tell you that in jail, and in jail alone, can a person get an occasion to study empirically the great social subjects of crime and sin. I have read some literature on this and only in jail is the proper place for self-study on all these topics. The best parts of self-study is to suffer oneself.

As for any suggestion that ‘jail life will crush all ideas’, he questions ‘whether the situation outside the jail was any bit more favourable to our ideas?’. He saw the use of the jail rules against the detainees as a source of strength to draw upon, pointing out how ‘we continued our work despite the testing environment of disappointments, pressures and violence ordained by the Jail rules’ and asks, ‘Were these conditions not testing in the extreme?’ He draws attention to ‘our revolutionary comrades who suffered for their convictions in Jails and are still working on return from jails’, referring to ‘Bakunin’ and pointing out how ‘[t]oday, you find many revolutionaries occupying responsible posts in the Russian state who passed the greater part of their lives in prison, completing their sentences’.[1] Simona Sawhney observes that, notwithstanding the